



Heat protection plan for Health of the BMG

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Contents

A) Initial situation	2
B) Objectives	2
C) Strategy for the summer periods	3
1. Make use of the DWD heat warning system standard 2. "Heat monitoring":	3
Improve early detection through monitoring	4
3. Heat protection campaign by the BMG	5
4. Protection of vulnerable groups	6
5. Institutionally anchor heat protection at the federal level – Concerted Action on Heat and IMA Heat Protection 8	

A) Initial situation

With climate change, the **occurrence of heat waves** has become increasingly likely.

These affect our health, our well-being and the performance of our Society. That is why Germany must prepare itself even better for future heat waves.

Every year, heat not only causes deaths but also affects the incidence of disease.

Preventive heat protection concerns us all: federal government – states – municipalities – institutions – The various political levels, the health sector and civil society are already committed to heat protection. In view of the growing threats, this commitment must be strengthened and further improved.

Climate Pact for Health, which was launched last year and is supported by

The Federal Ministry of Health (BMG), which is supported by the self-administration, states and municipalities, already exists as a platform for cooperative and joint action.

Since the great heat wave in 2003, which caused numerous deaths in Europe, various countries have improved heat protection. France, for example, as a centralized country, drew up a national heat protection plan (Plan National Canicule) in 2004, which is used every summer from June 1 to September 15.

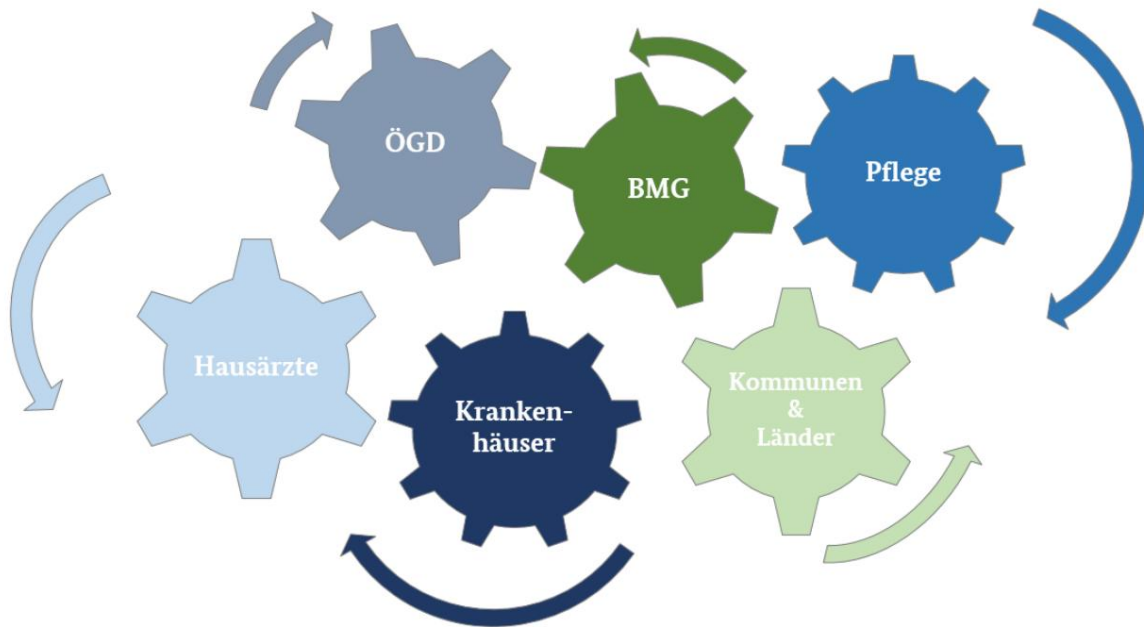
Building on the French experience, a heat protection plan is to be established for Germany as part of a concerted heat action – taking into account federal responsibilities and involving all those responsible.

B) Objectives

1. **Raising awareness among the population** and especially among vulnerable groups to take protective measures when heat waves occur.
2. **Reducing and preventing heat-related deaths** and mitigating disease progression.
3. **Triggering intervention and communication cascades** (triggering Protective measures) through targeted warning information.
4. **Improving and disseminating scientific evidence.**

C) Strategy for the summer periods

Verzahnung beim Hitzeschutz im Gesundheitswesen



The strategy is based on the following 5 building blocks:

1. Make use of the DWD heat warning system standard

- The heat warning system of the German Weather Service (DWD) is an excellent possibility to warn people of impending heat waves, also via digital solutions, and could in the future be the basis for triggering intervention cascades (<https://hitzewarnungen.de/index.jsp>).
- Efforts should be made to ensure that the DWD heat warning system is used routinely by all relevant actors and can be optimized in terms of its user-friendliness and communicability with regard to various requirements.
- The states should check whether warning levels of the DWD are compatible with the implementation. Acute measures can be mandatorily linked (e.g. measures in inpatient care facilities).
- In addition, further options are being examined as to how as many people as possible can be targeted. Digital solutions (e.g. apps, SMS) can warn about heat.

UPDATE

- ➡ Letter from the Minister of State for Culture and Media and the Federal Minister for Health to the public broadcasters with reference to the DWD heat warning system.
- ➡ Distribution of DWD heat warnings by BMG since July 7, 2023 (social media, press distribution list).
- ➡ Development of own heat protection plans by other states, e.g. Rhineland-Palatinate, following the 1st Heat Protection Conference.
- ➡ BMG will address heat protection at GMK in September 2023 (in particular linking DWD warning levels and triggering acute measures).
- ➡ Request from the BMG to use digital solutions (e.g. SMS, NINA warning app) for heat warnings to all government actors (federal departments, states, municipalities).
- ➡ BMUV, BMG and BMDV are examining whether heat warnings issued by the DWD should be extended. Indicators/information such as pollen forecast and maximum ground-level ozone concentration can be expanded.
- ➡ BMG will support a pilot project in the state of Berlin: App shows prospective places to cool down and protect yourself from the heat (e.g. drinking water fountains) and concrete tips on how to behave.

2. "Heat monitoring": Improve early detection through monitoring

- The Robert Koch Institute (RKI) is preparing a report on behalf of the BMG from June to September 2023, meaningful weekly evaluations of excess mortality due to heat in Germany will be available for the first time. The reports will be available on the RKI website at www.rki.de/hitzemortalitaet from June 22, 2023. published.
- However, there is currently a lack of data-based evidence to quickly identify unusual effects on morbidity, to act accordingly and, if necessary, to preventive measures. Against this background, the RKI will, where appropriate, adapt its health reporting to the French model (epidemiological surveillance, heat-related monitoring and evaluation of mortality and morbidity) step by step.

UPDATE

- ➡ First figures from the RKI report: In calendar weeks 15 to 28 in 2023, according to RKI estimates, there have been around 1,510 deaths due to heat - 880 of them in the 85+ age group.

- ➡ Exchange between BMG/RKI and experts (DWD, ZI, AKTIN, DGINA) to further improve the data-based recording of heat-related mortality and morbidity.
- ➡ Bilateral exchange with the French Ministry of Health on heat monitoring, in particular on the transferability of French to German heat monitoring.
- ➡ BMUV/BMG checks whether UV-related morbidity can be recorded.
- ➡ Commissioning of a scientific report to analyse the role of the public health service in heat protection measures.

3. Heat protection campaign by the BMG

- Promoting action knowledge in everyday life is an important protective factor. This is understandable for laypeople on the website <https://www.klima-mensch-gesundheit.de/> of the Federal Center for Health Education (BZgA) prepares and systematically expands the data.
- At the same time, prevention in everyday life must be strengthened. This is where local A practical tool for planning and implementing heat protection measures is the Heat Service Portal for Municipalities (LMU Munich), which was developed with funding from the Federal Ministry of Health and has been in operation since 26. June 2023 at <https://hitzeservice.de> is available online. In the future, the platform will also be used as an important component as soon as a warning level or an intervention cascade is triggered.
- The BMG's communication can be used by the state and local level and through **preventive communication** (through information to the responsible levels) and **communication in acute cases** (BZgA taking action during heat waves).
- Communication measures should be scientifically monitored and evaluated in order to be able to apply them in a targeted manner.

UPDATE

- ➡ Poster campaign by the BMG in cooperation with the BZgA (behavioral tips in hot weather). The poster contains a link (QR code) to the DWD heat warning system.
- ➡ Sending the poster to multipliers (e.g. doctors, municipalities, welfare associations or self-administration).
- ➡ Order free of charge at <https://shop.bzga.de/poster-was-tun-bei-grosser-hitze/> – also in larger order quantities.



Further development of the HeatService portal with a new research project "HeatService Interactive". In particular, strengthening heat protection through improved collaboration, networking and knowledge transfer.

4. Protection of vulnerable groups

The protection of vulnerable groups – such as the elderly, children, people with pre-existing illnesses, those in need of care, people living alone, people with disabilities, and the homeless – is the primary goal of heat prevention.

There are already various approaches that should be expanded. These include the following options:

- In order to provide direct support to care facilities in preparing for the hot months and protecting those in need of care, information on existing initiatives, concepts and projects will be made available to all care facilities as a first step. The care facility associations will discuss whether, in a second step, a nationwide recommendation for heat protection plans in care facilities and care services can provide additional guidance. The federal recommendation could be developed by the Nursing Quality Committee, for example. It will also be examined whether a heat officer can be appointed in care facilities and with what tasks.
- The BMG convenes a panel of experts to transfer analogous measures to the hospital sector.
- The health insurance companies support in cooperation with the public Health service Municipalities and operators of institutions and companies with their services for prevention and health promotion, particularly in the area of heat protection. Climate protection and adaptation elements are always integrated into preventive projects and measures. As part of the coalition agreement to revise the Prevention Act, the BMG will include the aspect of heat protection.
- We are discussing with the German Association of General Practitioners how general practitioners can make targeted contact with vulnerable patients.
- The BMG information campaign should also aim to increase civic Commitment to using existing offers during heat periods (e.g. neighbourhood assistance).
- To improve the accessibility of vulnerable groups, BMG is awarding a Scientific report systematically recording the various access routes, actors and approaches to action (award in summer/ result in early 2024).

- The states and the chambers (and, where applicable, professional associations or other providers of further and advanced training) are examining the extent to which further and advanced training for health professionals can be supplemented with specific aspects of heat protection.

UPDATE



Top-level meeting of the minister with nursing associations and nursing care funds at federal level on July 6, 2023. Concrete agreements:

- Ministerial letter to nursing services and inpatient care facilities. Objective:
Raising awareness of upcoming heat waves and providing specific information for care facilities. Information on heat protection in care is available on a special page in the German Care Network (<https://pflegenetzwerk-deutschland.de/thema-hitzeschutz>) available.
- BMG letter to the associations of those in need of care and those providing care
Relatives and nursing care funds to raise awareness of heat and to refer to the specific information available for people aged 65 and over on "klima-mensch-gesundheit.de" and to request that the information be disseminated among their members.
- Request to GKV-SV to address the issue of heat protection in the guidelines and
Agreements on care advice, advice in the home and in care courses for relatives/
volunteers must be addressed in a binding manner.
- Addressing the topic of "Heat protection in nursing" in the current issue of the nursing network newsletter.
- BMG proposal to the Nursing Quality Committee, by summer 2024
To adopt federal recommendations for heat protection.
- Development of a "One Pager" in cooperation with the BZgA especially for
People in need of care living at home and their relatives.



Information on heat protection is provided by individual health insurance companies, e.g. the BARMER heat hotline, which is available to all citizens. Individual private health insurance companies have set up hotlines for their customers (e.g. Gothaer Health Insurance). The same applies to individual municipalities (e.g. the city of Cologne).



- Joint initiative with the German General Practitioners Association (HÄV):
- Poster campaign by the BMG and the German General Practitioners Association (HÄV) to achieve vulnerable patient groups via general practitioners' practices
(<https://www.hausaerzteverband.de/themen/hitzeschutz/>)
 - Development / preparation of nationwide training concepts by the HÄV
on climate-resilient care (https://www.hausaerzteverband.de/fileadmin/user_upload/downloads/Hitze-Manual_HAEV_Juli_2023.pdf)

- BMG will propose to the legislator to anchor the corresponding advice in the remuneration system ("climate-resilient advice").



In August, the BMG invites you to the first expert roundtable on heat protection in hospitals.



The BMG will involve the public health service more closely in heat protection, especially in order to reach local medical, nursing and social facilities.



Heat protection for the homeless as a focus in the above-mentioned scientific report on the accessibility of vulnerable groups.



In the context of the ongoing process of updating the framework curricula and training plans, the expert commission pursuant to Section 53 PflBG pays particular attention to updating the existing recommendations of the framework training plans on the aspect of "environment, climate and health" in nursing training.

5. Institutionally anchor heat protection at the federal level – concerted

Action Heat and IMA Heat Protection

ÿ In order to effectively prevent and protect against heat, numerous to involve non-administrative actors. The BMG is therefore proposing a **"Concerted Action on Heat"** together with those involved in the "Climate Pact for Health" and other key actors for heat protection. With a **"status conference"** in autumn 2023, the Concerted Action will take stock and analyse existing concepts and resources for protective measures and evaluate the experiences of summer 2023. The work orders agreed in the Concerted Action will be processed by those involved and followed up in specialist working groups with the participation of the "Climate Pact". The focus of a **"season kick-off"** in spring 2024 will then be a preparedness check to compare how well Germany is prepared for the next heat waves and where adjustments may still need to be made.

ÿ The BMG, together with the BMUV, the BMI, the BMDV, the BMWSB, the BMAS, BKM, BMWK, BMEL and BMFSFJ and, if necessary, other ministries, will set up an **interministerial working group (IMA)** to address the issue of heat. The IMA will work on the federal government's contribution to effectively designing heat protection in Germany.

In addition, comprehensive solutions and response options are needed in the event of a very intense, exceptional heat wave, e.g. with drought, drinking water shortages, overload of hospitals, power outages, forest fires.

UPDATE



Bilateral talks between the BMG and BMUV, BKM, BMI, BMAS, BMDV and BMWSB on the contributions of the respective ministries and further/in-depth exchange within the framework of an interministerial working group.



While the current heat protection plan has implemented short-term measures in particular, the status conference in autumn 2023 and the IMA will be the place to prepare the medium and long-term measures for heat protection and to implement.